

HOW TO GET DOUBLE FOR YOUR TROUBLE

Blue denotes PPT slide

Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: Genesis 41:50-52 (NKJV) *“And to Joseph were born two sons before the years of famine came, whom Asenath, the daughter of Poti-Pherah priest of On, bore to him.*

⁵¹ Joseph called the name of the firstborn Manasseh: “For God has made me forget all my toil and all my father’s house.” ⁵² And the name of the second he called Ephraim: “For God has caused me to be fruitful in the land of my affliction.”

Joseph was one of the twelve sons of Jacob. At the age of seventeen, Joseph was employed as a shepherd in his family’s ranching business.

Without ever knowing names in this story, one could pretty well predict a head-on collision in the relationship department within this family:

- Jacob favored Rachel over Leah...
- Joseph was born to Jacob and Rachel late in life...
- Jacob favored Joseph above his other sons...

Joseph seemed to be on a fast track to success. He could convince his father of anything. His father rolled out the red carpet any time Joseph came around. It was obvious to the other brothers that Jacob was going to find a way to resource Joseph above anyone or anything else.

The actions of Jacob created an impasse in his family. More importantly, it created issues between his sons that were irreconcilable.

While Joseph seemed to be in the passing lane of life, he was about to hit a traffic jam. This traffic jam was going to set up a detour through

four great tests that would determine who Joseph could become.

The four great tests of Joseph's life were:
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- The test of Vision...
- The test of Character...
- The test of Patience...
- The test of Success...

THE TEST OF VISION

Because of the situation in his home, his brothers hated Joseph. John 15:18-20 (NKJV)

“If the world hates you, you know that it hated Me before it hated you. ¹⁹ If you were of the world, the world would love its own. Yet because you are not of the world, but I chose you out of the world, therefore the world hates you. ²⁰ Remember the word that I said to you,

‘A servant is not greater than his master.’ If they persecuted Me, they will also persecute you. If they kept My word, they will keep yours also.”

If we are able to live a life that really counts, we will attract some haters along the way. Shake the haters off! (Song: You Gotta Keep Walking) (Keep paddling your canoe)

As if the dysfunction in this family was not bad enough, Jacob gave Joseph a coat of many colors! The gifting of this coat of many colors was filled with meaning:

- It indicated special favor...
- It denoted covenant relationship...
- It signaled family leadership...

To add insult to injury, Joseph started to dream dreams of exaltation. (Binding sheaves in the field and the sheaves of his father, mother and

brothers bowing down to his sheave; Dream of the sun, moon and eleven stars bowing down to him) When we start telling our dream, people are going to react:

- Some will be excited...
- Some will be supportive...
- Some will be helpful...
- Some will be skeptical...
- Some will exert resistance...
- Some will be absolutely hateful...

When Joseph told his dream, no one was excited, supportive, or helpful!

Jacob, who thought Joseph was “*Da Man*,” was very skeptical.

His brothers, who already had issues with him, did not react very well to the unveiling of Joseph’s dreams. [Genesis 37:3-5 \(NKJV\)](#) “*Now Israel loved Joseph more than all his children, because he was the son of his old age. Also he*

made him a tunic of many colors. ⁴ But when his brothers saw that their father loved him more than all his brothers, they hated him and could not speak peaceably to him. ⁵ Now Joseph had a dream, and he told it to his brothers; and they hated him even more.”

It is very disappointing, even downright deflating, when we roll our vision out and the very people we thought would be excited about it, resist it and even hate us because of it.

No one accomplishes a vision without some pockets of resistance and a few haters. Mark my word...every God sized vision will be tested.

Just because we hit some resistance does not mean we have the wrong vision! Just because we acquire some haters along the way is no indication that we should:

- Give up...
- Throw in the towel...

- Raise the flag of surrender...
- Let the fat lady start singing...

Joseph's brothers conspired to kill him, but Reuben said “*Let's put him in a pit, and leave him there.*” Reuben planned to return later and deliver Joseph unto his father. Reuben was hoping that with a little time things would calm down.

The brothers of Joseph failed to consider that the tallest tree was once a sapling. We must be careful how we treat people as we ascend the ladder of success; we may need their assistance as we come back down.

Every God sized vision is planned through the pit. No dream will be accomplished until it has been thoroughly tested. This means we will more than likely experience times when we look at where the vision has taken us and say, “*This is the pits!*”

Just because our vision has driven us to the pits, is no excuse for us to give up on the vision! If we stay with the vision, the very dream we rode into the pit will be the one that will drive us out of the pit! 2 Corinthians 1:8-10 (NKJV) *“For we do not want you to be ignorant, brethren, of our trouble which came to us in Asia: that we were burdened beyond measure, above strength, so that we despaired even of life. 9 Yes, we had the sentence of death in ourselves, that we should not trust in ourselves but in God who raises the dead, 10 who delivered us from so great a death, and does deliver us; in whom we trust that He will still deliver us, “*

Joseph’s brothers took his coat away from him, then dipped it in animal blood and gave it to Jacob telling him, *“Some wild animal probably killed Joseph.”* Reuben is the only brother who showed any compassion toward Joseph. Reuben

intended to return to the pit and retrieve Joseph but it was not to be so.

When our vision is being tested, there will be well-intentioned people who can see it and believe it, but because of the peer pressure, cannot muster the courage to break with the crowd and embrace it. How disappointing! (Chickens)

The rest of the brothers placed Joseph in the pit long enough to find some slave traders who were willing to buy him. When our vision is being tested, there will be people we trust in our circle of influence, who will sell us down the river. Psalm 55:12-14 (CEV) *“My enemies are not the ones who sneer and make fun. I could put up with that or even hide from them.”¹³ But it was my closest friend, the one I trusted most.¹⁴ We enjoyed being together, and we went with others to your house, our God. “*

Joseph's vision was being tested to the limit and ours will be as well. There is no such thing as an untested vision. *"If you limit your choices only to what seems possible or reasonable, you disconnect yourself from what you truly want, and all that is left is a compromise."* - Robert Fritz **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)**

We may experience times when we have been sold down the river, but if it is a God vision, our canoe can withstand the current.

Joseph was brought out of the pit and sold to the Ishmaelite slave traders for 20 pieces of silver. When our vision is being tested, the light at the end of the tunnel is often an oncoming train.

If we can ride the test until it becomes a testimony, the vision God has given us will not only survive, it will thrive! *Jeremiah 29:11 (NKJV) "For I know the thoughts that I think*

toward you, says the LORD, thoughts of peace and not of evil, to give you a future and a hope.”

If we have a vision, it will be tested. What kind of price are we willing to pay to follow God to reveal our destiny?

To get double for our trouble, we must be able to pass the vision test. To pass the vision test we must believe:

- The vision is more important than our comfort...
- The vision is more important than public opinion...
- The vision is more important than the opposition...

How important is the vision? Can we pass the vision test? If we want double for our trouble, the vision will need to be tested. Are we up to

the test? What will we do? Will we rise above the fray or embrace an inferior idea?

SONG: *“I’m Still Standing”*

THE TEST OF CHARACTER

Genesis 39:1-6 (KJV) *“And Joseph was brought down to Egypt; and Potiphar, an officer of Pharaoh, captain of the guard, an Egyptian, bought him of the hands of the Ishmaelites, which had brought him down thither. ² And the LORD was with Joseph, and he was a prosperous man; and he was in the house of his master the Egyptian. ³ And his master saw that the LORD was with him, and that the LORD made all that he did to prosper in his hand. ⁴ And Joseph found grace in his sight, and he served him: and he made him overseer over his house, and all that he had he put into his hand. ⁵ And it came to pass from the time that he had made him overseer in his*

house, and over all that he had, that the LORD blessed the Egyptian's house for Joseph's sake; and the blessing of the LORD was upon all that he had in the house, and in the field. ⁶ And he left all that he had in Joseph's hand; and he knew not ought he had, save the bread which he did eat. And Joseph was a goodly person, and well favoured.”

The Ishmaelite slave traders sold Joseph to Potiphar, an officer of Pharaoh. Potiphar was a very successful Egyptian businessman, and early on he noticed that the Lord was with Joseph. As Joseph worked for Potiphar, everything he touched seemed to turn to gold.

In time, Potiphar turned everything he had over to Joseph, and consequently Joseph became the chief operating officer of his house and business enterprises. God prospered Joseph as Potiphar's

COO, and Potiphar realized some very hefty profits.

The character test began when Potiphar's wife began to flirt with Joseph. This flirtation turned to proposition as Joseph steadfastly resisted her advances. I do not believe Mrs. Potiphar was an ugly woman. Temptation is always attractive.

“There is pleasure in sin for a season.”

In the house of Potiphar, Joseph found himself embroiled in a fight for his character. This fight was not about mere resistance; it was about whether Joseph would ever realize his vision.

Joseph refused to give in because he was determined to get double for his trouble!

Joseph was:

1) Young and lonely... [1 Timothy 4:12 \(NKJV\)](#)

“Let no one despise your youth, but be an

example to the believers in word, in conduct, in love, in spirit, in faith, in purity.”

2) Suffering from rejection... Psalm 27:10 (NKJV) *“When my father and my mother forsake me, then the Lord will take care of me.”*

3) Away from home... No one would know, would they? Job 28:24 (AMP) *“For He looks to the ends of the earth and sees everything under the heavens.”* Job 23:10 (NKJV) *“He knows the way that I take; when He has tested me, I shall come forth as gold.”*

4) Especially vulnerable at all levels... Isaiah 43:1-2 (NKJV) *“But now, thus says the LORD, who created you, O Jacob, and He who formed you, O Israel: “Fear not, for I have redeemed you; I have called you by your name; You are Mine. ² When you pass through the waters, I will be with you; and through the*

rivers, they shall not overflow you. When you walk through the fire, you shall not be burned, nor shall the flame scorch you.”

Listen to the guiding principle of Joseph’s battle for his own character and his effort to get double for his trouble. Genesis 39:7-9 (NKJV)

“It came to pass after these things that his master’s wife cast longing eyes on Joseph, and she said, “Lie with me.”⁸ But he refused and said to his master’s wife, “Look, my master does not know what is with me in the house, and he has committed all that he has to my hand.⁹ There is no one greater in this house than I, nor has he kept back anything from me but you, because you are his wife. How then can I do this great wickedness, and sin against God?”

Joseph was more concerned about sinning against God than disappointing his parents or

defaming his religion. *“There is no such thing as a minor lapse of integrity.”* – Tom Peters

“A person who is fundamentally honest doesn't need a code of ethics. The Ten Commandments and the Sermon on the Mount are all the ethical code anybody needs.” – Harry S. Truman

If we can be faithful despite the test of our character, we move one step closer to getting double for our trouble.

The battle for Joseph's integrity reached such a crescendo that one day, while fulfilling his assignments, Potiphar's wife made one last effort to get Joseph to fail the integrity test. When her advances were denied, she accused this man of character, of attempted rape.

To pass the character test we must:

- Be honest with God and man...
- Refuse to bow at the altar of compromise...

- Stay the course when others take ethical detours...

If one passes the character test, he/she is one step closer to getting double for their trouble.

Mark Twain said, *“You cannot depend on your eyes when your imagination is out of focus.”*

(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL END OF SERMON)

THE TEST OF SUCCESS

Genesis 41:39-44 (CEV) *“The king told Joseph, “God is the one who has shown you these things. No one else is as wise as you are or knows as much as you do. ⁴⁰ I’m putting you in charge of my palace, and everybody will have to obey you. No one will be over you except me. ⁴¹ You are now governor of all Egypt!” ⁴² Then the king took off his royal ring and put it on Joseph’s finger. He gave him fine clothes to wear and placed a gold chain*

around his neck. ⁴³ He also let him ride in the chariot next to his own, and people shouted, “Make way for Joseph!” So Joseph was governor of Egypt. ⁴⁴ The king told Joseph, “Although I’m king, no one in Egypt is to do anything without your permission.”

Joseph was about to discover that the test of success would be his greatest test to date. How we handle success reveals who we really are.

“Nearly all men can stand adversity, but if you want to test a man's character, give him power.” — Abraham Lincoln

Most people think when success comes everything will be smooth sailing. The truth is the test of success reveals things about us that neither others, nor we, knew previously.

Once Joseph settled into his new responsibilities, he married and God gave him two sons. *Genesis 41:50-52 (MSG) “Joseph*

had two sons born to him before the years of famine came. Asenath, daughter of Potiphera the priest of On, was their mother. Joseph named the firstborn Manasseh (Forget), saying, “God made me forget all my hardships and my parental home.” He named his second son Ephraim (Double Prosperity), saying, “God has prospered me in the land of my sorrow.”

In Bible days parents rarely named their children based on what they thought sounded good, they named them for something of great significance in their lives. Genesis 41:51 (MSG)
“Joseph named the firstborn Manasseh (Forget), saying, “God made me forget all my hardships and my parental home.” What does Manasseh mean? It means forgetfulness.

By naming his son Manasseh (Forgetfulness), Joseph is not saying that he had forgotten about

what his brothers had put him through. He had certainly not lost the memory of his father, mother, or brothers. When his brothers came to buy corn in Egypt, they did not recognize Joseph, but he immediately recognized them.

By naming his son Manasseh, he was saying God had taken the pain out of a past experience for him. If we intend to pass the success test and get double for our trouble, we must release the pain of the past.

When we fail to release those who have hurt us, we are constantly tethered to the past. (Illustrate this)

Being tethered to the past causes us to spend more time peering into what happened at a former intersection of our life rather than following the GPS (Gods Plan directed by the Spirit) into our future. *"If you limit your choices only to what seems possible or reasonable, you disconnect yourself from what you truly want, and all that*

is left is a compromise."

— Robert Fritz

If anyone had reason to be bitter and have a critical attitude, certainly Joseph did. What's our excuse? If we are bitter or critical we need to ask ourselves:

- Have we been kidnapped or held against our will?
- Did our siblings put us in a pit or sell us into slavery?
- Have we spent years in prison as a result of false charges?
- Have we been separated from our families against our will for thirteen years?

When his first son was born, Joseph named him Manasseh, ***“The Lord hath made me to forget”***

The proof is unmistakable that Joseph had allowed God to take the pain out of a past

experience and allowed forgiveness to replace the hurt:

- He did not retaliate against the butler...
- He did not even the score with Mrs. Potiphar...
- He did not take revenge against his brothers...
- He blessed his father's house when he could have exterminated them...

Un-forgiveness locks the victim in a self-imposed prison. The only means of escape is for the offended to forgive the offender.

Please allow me to ask some questions about what we plan to do when we achieve the success we have been working toward:

- Are we going to flaunt the success before our naysayers?

- Are we going to retaliate against those who have opposed us?
- Are we going to exact revenge on those who have caused us pain?
- Are we going to undo the success of those who stepped on our fingers while they were climbing the ladder of success?
- Are we going to develop a bad attitude toward those who have treated us with a lack of dignity and respect along the way?

The test of success is not as easy as it seems.

Joseph named his first son Manasseh so that every time he referred to his son by name, it was a constant reminder that he could not afford to let un-forgiveness and bitterness cloud the vision God had called him to. Joseph intended to get double for his trouble, and he knew that he had to forgive to get it!

If we allow the pain of past experiences to become the guiding principle in our lives, we will fail the success test and become another statistic on the trash heap of human wreckage. If we refuse to forgive, we will never know the joy of receiving double for our trouble.

If Joseph could endure all this and forget the past, surely you and I can forget the past and serve God victoriously. [Philippians 3:13-14 \(NKJV\)](#) *“Brethren, I do not count myself to have apprehended; but one thing I do, forgetting those things which are behind and reaching forward to those things which are ahead, ¹⁴ I press toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus.”*

I want us to look at two very important aspects of the test of success:

- What should we forget? We should forget past hurts – past failures – past successes.

- How do I forget? Forgive – give up on the need to get even – turn retribution over to God – move on with our lives – expend our energy and resources moving toward the vision, rather than trying to make sure the naysayers have been dealt with. **Romans 12:19 (KJV) *Dearly beloved, avenge not yourselves, but rather give place unto wrath: for it is written, “Vengeance is mine; I will repay,” saith the Lord.***

If we want double for our trouble, we should pay close attention to the actions of Joseph when his brothers came to Egypt to purchase corn:

- He sold them corn and put their money back in their sacks.
- He kept Simeon so that they would bring Benjamin (a brother he had never met) back

with them. When they returned, he made a feast for them.

- He sold them corn and supplies and once again put their money back in their sacks.
- He placed his silver cup in Benjamin's sack and let them go.
- After they left, he sent his servants to retrieve them.
- His servants searched their belongings and of course found Joseph's silver cup in Benjamin's sack.

His brothers pleaded for mercy and Joseph revealed his true identity. [Genesis 45:7-8 \(KJV\)](#)
“And God sent me before you to preserve you a posterity in the earth, and to save your lives by a great deliverance. ⁸ So now it was not you that sent me hither, but God: and he hath made me a father to Pharaoh, and lord of all

his house, and a ruler throughout all the land of Egypt.”

The real story here is the reason for Joseph’s ascent to a position of influence; he forgave his brothers before they asked for forgiveness.

How could he do such a thing? Because “*The Lord hath made me to forget.*”

Please note: From the time Joseph was named Prime Minister until his brothers arrived in Egypt to buy corn, was approximately nine years.

We are made aware that Joseph had two sons, the name of his second son was Ephraim. Ephraim means, “*Double fruit.*”

Genesis 41:52 (KJV) “*And the name of the second called he Ephraim: For God hath*

caused me to be fruitful in the land of my affliction.”

There are 2 things here for us to note:

- God caused Joseph to be fruitful. We must recognize that all success comes from God.
- God caused Joseph to be fruitful in the land of his affliction. Anyone can succeed when everything is going right! God is looking for people who have the tenacity to succeed in the good times as well as the bad times.

God is looking for some folks that can blossom despite the circumstances and surroundings and maintain their integrity throughout the onslaught of success.

How did God bless him?

- Financially... He became the Prime Minister and received the salary that went with such a position!

- Family... A wife and two sons! It doesn't get any better than that! Every time Joseph called one of his sons by name, he was reminding himself of the miracles of God!
- Position... Joseph's authority was second only to Pharaoh! Not too bad for an illegal immigrant!

CONCLUSION:

Though Joseph experienced the zenith of his success in Egypt, it was never home to Joseph. According to the Scripture, we are also *“pilgrims and strangers”* here. We are living in the land of affliction, so to speak.

Joseph lived in the land of affliction, but he walked uprightly before God. Because he walked uprightly before God, God blessed him.

No matter how good or difficult the journey becomes, we must keep in mind that this world

is not our end game. Joseph had a good run in Egypt, but listen to what he says just before his death. Genesis 50:24-25 (KJV) *And Joseph said unto his brethren, “I die: and God will surely visit you, and bring you out of this land unto the land which he sware to Abraham, to Isaac, and to Jacob.”*²⁵ *And Joseph took an oath of the children of Israel, saying, “God will surely visit you, and ye shall carry up my bones from hence.”*